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1. Introduction and Context

Effective people management is recognised as essential for organisational success due to its contribution to converting employee potential into strategic success (Lepak & Gowan, 2010). The luxury fashion business is no exception to this assertion insofar as skills and services depend on people at least as much as products. The Burberry Group Plc is a business established in 1856; its headquarters are situated in London. It sells products via company-operated stores, concessions, wholesale distribution and Burberry.com in over 140 countries and territories around the world (Burberry Group plc, 2026). The market situation itself is not favourable either; sales of the global personal luxury goods industry decreased by 2% to €358 billion in 2025 at constant exchange rates. The case is relevant to analysis because of the pressure under which the people management strategy in the company has to be built up again. Revenues fell down to £2,461 million in FY 2024/25 and adjusted operating profit dropped to £26 million from £418 million (Burberry Group plc, 2026). The November 2024 launch of Burberry Forward was an initiative by the Chief Executive Officer Joshua Schulman, comprising a four-pillar strategy, with the people pillar striving to create a new high-performance culture at Burberry (Burberry Group plc, 2026). The organisational changes involved 1,700 jobs, saved the company £80 million in FY 2025/26 and incurred restructuring costs of £45 million in the same period, mainly relating to redundancies and consultants (Burberry Group plc, 2026). In addition to the job losses, there were 294 internal promotions, 640 lateral movements, simplified performance framework and constant or improved levels of engagement scores (Burberry Group plc, 2026). From Burberry's disclosure, the use of digital means includes the use of a digital learning platform, the introduction of the B: Managers Hub for line managers in October 2025 and the B: Heard system of pulse and annual surveys (Burberry Group plc, 2026). This report will look into how Burberry manages its people with a focus on both traditional HR practices and digital HR practices. It will focus on recruitment, learning and development, performance management and reward in regard to the former and e-HRM systems and people analytics in regard to the latter. It is important because while digital HR allows for increased efficiency and sound decision making, it can undermine the relational aspect of people management that a heritage brand relies upon, and comes at a time when Burberry is in the midst of downsizing staff, which means employee trust is low. Consequently, the research paper suggests that digital HR should be used by Burberry as an addition rather than a replacement to the current system of managing people, and achieving success through it will depend on its alignment with strategy and manager competency and trustworthiness. This

research paper provides a theoretical framework and rationale for the sequence of the chosen theories, and then uses it to analyse Burberry's current practices and issues related to the implementation of digital HR.

2. Theoretical Framework

2.1 Choice and order of theories

The current report does not cover all the people management models available. Instead, five interrelated frameworks have been selected that answer different questions of the brief. Strategic Human Resource Management outlines the reason why people management is needed. The Human Resource systems and the Human Resource function frameworks cover the organisation of practices and their delivery. The Team Theory framework outlines the ways groups of people are created. The Digital Human Resource Management framework outlines changes caused by technology. In this order, first comes the purpose, then the organisation, then the change caused by technology, and finally the conditions under which the change will be successful. The purposeful location of Digital Human Resource Management is essential. Technology becomes valuable only after understanding its purpose and the practices behind it, and it can succeed only in case of the response of employees (Strohmeier, 2020; Tambe et al., 2019). Otherwise, the use of technology would imply its solution to an undetermined problem. Every framework includes a core text and peer-reviewed literature.

2.2 Strategic HRM and fit

According to Armstrong & Taylor (2020), HRM refers to an integrated and strategic approach to the employment, development and well-being of people in the organisation. The strategic aspect is the idea that people practices should align with organizational goals and supports the argument that people management plays a key role in achieving strategic objectives (Lepak & Gowan, 2010). There are two debates that are relevant to this research question. The first one is that of best practice and best fit. While universalist models argue that a certain set of high commitment practices improves performance in all organisations, contingency models argue that these practices need to align with the strategy and context of the organisation (Armstrong & Taylor, 2020; Wilkinson et al., 2017). The second one is that of hard and soft HRM. Hard HRM models view employees as a cost to control, and soft models view them as an asset to develop (Bratton & Gold, 2017). Both of these debates are relevant to the context of an organisation cutting costs but attempting to transform its culture. The reality is that this line is

rather blurry, as an organisation may express its position in soft terms but pursue a hard course of action.

However, this approach has certain drawbacks. In their review of 495 empirical papers with respect to 516 HR systems, Boon et al. (2019) discovered that very little of this research actually tests synergy assumptions among practices. Moreover, indicators applied were inconsistent. Thus, an assumption about synergies within bundles is better explained by theory rather than empirical evidence. The report takes the best-fit approach as the approach which is better justified. Strategic human resource management serves as a criterion to assess the coherence of practices rather than a method to prove their effectiveness.

2.3 HR systems and the role of HR specialists

A strategy will only be useful when a person decides to put it into action. According to Torrington et al. (2017) and Armstrong & Taylor (2020), the Human Resources department plays many different roles, normally within the context of a business partner model that distinguishes between strategic partnering, shared services and specialisms. As this reflects what Human Resources specialists do other than administration, there is another drawback associated with this model. Distinguishing strategic activities from transactional ones means that business partners are further removed from day-to-day operations and leaves shared services with dull and powerless work. Digitalisation could accentuate this separation as automation of administration is its key promise (Strohmeier, 2020). The above model is therefore chosen to examine who owns decisions about people and how technology changes this ownership. It should be noted that context is important as well, as the listed private company is affected by shareholders' and market pressures.

2.4 Setting up teams

Mathieu et al. (2019) present a decade of team effectiveness literature from the perspective of the input, mediators, and outputs model. According to the authors, effectiveness depends on structural aspects such as task complexity and interdependence, compositional aspects such as member characteristics and diversity, and mediating mechanisms like team processes and emergent states including cohesiveness, trust, and psychological safety. The authors also perceive teams as complex and dynamic systems which continuously evolve depending on their environment; thus, team design should be adjusted dynamically. The model is appropriate for this report since reorganisation affects structural and compositional aspects of teams, while its consequences become obvious in the form of trust and cohesiveness. However, the model

has a limitation in terms of scope. It contains plenty of variables but offers no recommendations to managers regarding which of them to prioritise. Thus, the model is used in this report as a tool for diagnostics rather than prescription. Trust and psychological safety deserve special attention since they are emergent states created during interactions.

2.5 Digital HRM

While Strohmeier (2020) distinguishes between digitisation, which is the technical transformation of the information about HR into digital form, and digitalisation, which is the application of its potential to achieve certain HR purposes, his typology contains four ideal types: analogue HRM; digital HRM I, when technology replaces certain HR practices; digital HRM II, when technology is used for implementing the strategy developed irrespective of its digital potential; and digital HRM III, when digital potential is the basis for developing HR strategy. This provides the framework for the classification of the tools used by the organisation and testing the hypothesis of the correlation between their amount and the strategic approach to HR management. It can be supposed that HR analytics is a candidate for the third type, while complete digital HRM has not yet been achieved.

The evidence on their effectiveness is somewhat more restrained. According to Tambe et al. (2019), there are four key issues for the implementation of AI and data science in HR, namely the intricacy of HR outcomes, limited data sets, the need for fairness and accountability, and worker resistance to algorithmic decisions. These authors suggest focusing on causal reasoning, experimenting, and engaging employees in the process. Kellogg et al. (2020) prove that algorithms become a type of control when they direct, evaluate, and discipline workers and that employees resist it. Thus, digital HRM is again linked to the hard and soft management distinction because the same system can be regarded as either developmental or controlling depending on how its data is applied. According to Meijerink & Bondarouk (2021), algorithmic management both empowers and constrains employees' freedom and value, cautioning against the oversimplified view of digital tools being good or bad. Further, Tursunbayeva et al. (2022) assert that people analytics has ethical concerns such as biases, surveillance, and mistrust among workers and that scholarly literature on the subject is at an early stage of development and consists of only 14 relevant articles. This research contributes to the critical nature of the digital lens. It is not a matter of whether Burberry uses digital tools, but rather their type, the data used, and the employees' response.

2.6 Employee-centred conditions for success

The last set of questions relates to whether the change initiatives benefit the people involved. The findings by Peccei & Van De Voorde (2019), who analysed 46 articles published over the period from 2000 to 2018, revealed that the most common HR change models are based on mutual gains in which the practices contribute to employee well-being and performance simultaneously. In other words, there is very limited evidence that the outcomes are conflicting. These findings corroborate the idea of mutual benefits that good HR practice can bring to both parties. However, at the same time, they reveal the scope of research. It is necessary to analyse whether mutual gains will be achieved in the case of downsizing rather than make assumptions about this. Within the context of such a case, the issue of the psychological contract as suggested by Armstrong and Taylor (2020) becomes particularly relevant. Tursunbayeva et al. (2022) analyse this problem through the prism of a social contract between employers and their employees. Tambe et al. (2019) draw similar conclusions but from a technological perspective by suggesting that employees should be involved in the design of data-based tools, which is one of the ways to preserve the trust.

2.7 How the lenses fit together

It all comes together to form a single analytical lens. Strategic HRM provides the measure of coherence. The HR management function and team theory illustrate how practices and structures operate. The typology provided by Strohmeier categorises the digital tools. The employee-oriented lens checks whether the issues of trust and wellbeing have been protected. There are certain limitations of the framework used. It combines theories at the organisational and individual level which do not necessarily complement each other, while some of the digital evidence comes from an environment where there is a greater degree of algorithmic control compared to the HR department of a luxury corporation, and therefore the transferability remains an assumption. Other frameworks were considered. Using only the Harvard framework would allow covering the issues of stakeholders and outcomes but not those of the digital tools. Applying only a technology adoption framework would explain the issue of acceptance but not strategy and team design.

3. Application of Theories, Analysis and Discussion

3.1 Traditional HR practices and strategic fit

People practices of Burberry reflect the strategic rationale outlined in the model. People is one of the four pillars of the Burberry Forward strategy, and its goal is to reignite a high-

performance culture (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 17). It emerged in the wake of a poor year when revenue dropped to £2,461 million and adjusted operating profit to £26 million (see Table 1). This fact sheds light on the reason for the transformation of practices to match the turnaround, and this is how the best fit model is supported (Armstrong & Taylor, 2020; Wilkinson et al., 2017). Talent reviews were made at Executive Committee level and cascaded throughout the company, and performance management was streamlined based on feedback from colleagues (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 34).

It is the same data that demonstrates how hard HRM and soft HRM work hand in hand (Bratton & Gold, 2017). About 1,700 posts were affected, and restructuring expenses of £45 million primarily consisted of redundancy costs and consultancy fees (Burberry Group plc, 2026, pp. 29, 34). Nevertheless, there was an emphasis in the annual report on the values of belonging, purpose, and development, as well as a goal to foster a culture of cost consciousness (p. 24). The language is soft here, but decisions are hard, so Burberry has to be evaluated through results, not vocabulary.

Recruitment and development have some practices to demonstrate. Burberry applies standard interview forms, gender-neutral job descriptions, and mandatory unconscious bias training for recruitment professionals and hiring managers (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-b). In its internal UK apprenticeship program, there was a 77% increase in completions and 18% of its alumni got promoted (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 34). It is a typical approach (Armstrong & Taylor, 2020), but any digital one is based on this level.

Table 1: Burberry Forward, key figures

Measure	FY 2024/25	FY 2025/26
Revenue	£2,461m	£2,420m
Adjusted operating profit	£26m	£160m
Comparable retail sales growth	-12%	+2%
Restructurin	£29m	£45m

g charges		
Cost savings delivered	n/a	£80m (£100m annualised expected in FY 2026/27)

Source: Burberry Group plc (2026, pp. 4 to 5, 7, 26, 29).

These results are only partially observable. According to Burberry, engagement scores have improved or remained stable (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 35); however, the section on the company's culture provides no scores or response rate information (p. 117), which means that this claim is not observable. Reward information is inconsistent. In the UK, the median gender pay gap increased from 14.9% to 15.5%, while the mean gender pay gap decreased from 21.0% to 20.2%, and the mean bonus gap decreased from 66.0% to 38.0% (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-c). This complicates a simplistic mutual gains interpretation (Peccei & Van De Voorde, 2019), while Boon et al. (2019) suggest that synergy among practices cannot be assumed automatically. Burberry provides information about a wide range of HR practices. It does not provide information about their mutual reinforcement.

3.2 The HR function and team design

There is minimal information on the nature of the HR function at Burberry from public sources; therefore, it is only possible to examine the business partner approach (Torrington et al., 2017) in an indirect manner. The job adverts mention job positions for HR systems, including employee assistance via the AskHR portal, as well as HR analysis (Burberry Group plc, n.d.). This supports the existence of a separation of specialist and service activities, though it is just an assumption based on advert content rather than direct evidence of the organisation. A Chief People Officer has been mentioned as one of the senior managers (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 113).

Team design demonstrates structural and compositional evolution under Mathieu et al. (2019). The Executive Committee consists of Regional Presidents, the Chief Operating and Supply Chain Officer, and a Chief Customer Officer (a new position appointed internally), while ready-to-wear design was divided into dedicated womenswear and menswear teams (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 34). It is the mediating mechanisms that are the most important. Burberry reacted to the downsizing by organising seven CEO-led global town halls (p. 40) and senior leader workshops on leading through transformation (p. 34). Leadership is an appropriate leverage point. According to a study of 274 private sector employees in Pakistan,

transformational leadership decreased the negative effects of downsizing on commitment; however, a one-country sample limits the generalizability (Samreen et al., 2022). Burberry does not present any team-level evidence to support its claims regarding agility.

3.3 Digital HR tools

Table 2: Burberry's digital HR tools classified using Strohmeier (2020)

Tool or practice	Evidence	Classification (author's judgement)
Go1 learning platform; B: Managers Hub	Go1 tracks participation and topics; Hub launched October 2025 (Burberry Group plc, 2026, pp. 34, 116)	Digital HRM I
SAP SuccessFactors; UKG Pro WFM; AskHR ticketing	Named in HR systems job advertisements (Burberry Group plc, n.d)	Digital HRM I
B: Heard Engagement and Pulse surveys; targeted surveys	Two surveys a year, plus surveys after promotion or leave (Burberry Group plc, 2026, pp. 35, 116)	Digital HRM II
Diversity dashboard; people analytics reports	Shared quarterly with the Executive Committee (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-b, n.d.-d)	Digital HRM II
"Data-driven decision-making"	Priority is to drive sales, not HR (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 24)	Not classified

The tools are largely positioned operationally. Tools Go1, B: Managers Hub and the HR system implement or automate existing processes, which corresponds to Digital HRM I. The survey and the dashboard align better with Digital HRM II because the data feeds cultural indicators analysed by the Board and linked to specific pillars of strategy (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 116, 117). Public information shows no evidence of Digital HRM III, whereby digital possibilities drive HR strategy. The classification is based on publicly available resources and job ads, so it might under-represent internal processes. However, it is just a judgement rather than a finding. According to Strohmeier (2020), one of the opportunities of HR analytics is Digital HRM III. In a 2023 ad for an HR reporting position, training guides for users of people

analytics reports are listed among responsibilities (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-d). This can be seen as the foundation, but the foundation does not equal the strategy.

The techniques are largely descriptive. They gauge learning, sentiment, and diversity rather than predict or control behaviour; hence, algorithmic control as outlined by Kellogg et al. (2020) is not as pressing as data quality and trust. Workforce scheduling is the area of interest. Should UKG Pro WFM automate rosters, then the enabling and constraining effects of algorithms on autonomy would matter (Meijerink & Bondarouk, 2021).

3.4 Challenges of moving towards digital HR

Trust is the first problem, and time adds to it. As Burberry develops its digital technology, approximately 1,700 positions are at stake. Employee distrust emerges as a people analytics problem according to Tursunbayeva et al. (2022), and negative employee response to data-driven decisions is observed by Tambe et al. (2019). Job insecurity due to downsizing can create stress, resulting in reduced commitment (Samreen et al., 2022). Targeted surveys and the Global Workforce Advisory Forum are reasonable routes (Burberry Group plc, 2026, pp. 35, 115), yet without public results, one cannot judge the level of trust.

The second is the data quality. The ethnicity data are captured for 76.1% of UK colleagues, and the self-declaration is on a voluntary basis (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-c). According to Burberry, the company is working on improving the HR system to capture more of these data (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-b). Scale is another constraint that is related to data quality. The workforce was approximately 8,500 employees in April 2025, with approximately 3,000 UK-based employees (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-c) from over 140 countries and territories (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 14).

The third issue is access. Burberry has 410 company-operated stores (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 28) and heritage manufacturing in Yorkshire; hence, many employees work outside offices. There is no information provided on how store and factory employees interact with Go1 or the HR technology. This is something to be tested rather than found out. Retail Forward programmes are targeted at store teams (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 35); hence, there is already an established channel to the front line that can be utilised through digital channels.

The fourth issue is the cost. Savings were £80 million in FY 2025/26, and it is forecast that they will reach the annualisation level of £100 million in FY 2026/27, with an additional £5 million of restructuring charges forecast (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 29). The capital expenditure dropped from £151 million to £113 million and is guided towards about £120

million, with IT infrastructure, which includes digital, being among its uses (pp. 28, 29, 32). There is no HR technology budget available, and hence digital HR should fight for funding under the priority of cost discipline (p. 24).

Regulation is the fifth one. According to Burberry, personal information is gathered in accordance with market regulation (Burberry Group plc, n.d.-b). Furthermore, Tursunbayeva et al. (2022) mention legal uncertainties related to people analytics, including GDPR. Conducting business in multiple countries increases the expenses of the consistent practice of HR data usage.

3.5 Factors that shape successful application

These recurring themes are three. The first one is the aspect of measurement. Boon et al. (2019) and Peccei & Van De Voorde (2019) point out that any claims about HR's impact require evidence, which is not provided by Burberry in terms of scoring, response rates, and attrition numbers (Burberry Group plc, 2026, pp. 116, 117). The second theme is leadership capability. It is tackled by B: Managers Hub and leadership workshops, and the testimony of survivors confirms the importance of this factor, precisely in the case of ambiguous positions (Samreen et al., 2022). Finally, the third theme is employee participation. It was pointed out by Tambe et al. (2019), who called for employee involvement in the development of tools, and in the case of Burberry colleague-designed performance (Burberry Group plc, 2026, p. 34), it proved effective. Overall, Burberry's people management strategy is strategically coherent and digitally operational, but there is little evidence about its impact on employees. A heritage company that relies on craft and service must use digital HR to complement relations-based practices, which would require trust, data integrity and managerial capabilities.

4. Conclusion and Recommendations

4.1 Conclusion

The report sought to investigate how Burberry manages its people, the position of digital HR within this process, the constraints facing future development and what should be done by Burberry going forward. Through the lens of strategic HRM, the HR function, team design, digital HRM and the employee-centred approach, it can be concluded that people management at Burberry is strategically aligned, yet evidence is thin. The practices adopted adhere to the Burberry Forward strategy, and talent reviews, simpler performance management and internal mobility suit the firm's turnaround situation. Hard decisions, including those involving 1,700 roles impacted, must coexist alongside the softer rhetoric of 'belonging', and thus the company must be measured in terms of the results delivered for its people. The technologies used are largely operational or descriptive in nature, being aligned with the first two digital HRM types, and public sources confirm there is no strategic adoption of digital data in the context of HRM at Burberry. The major constraints facing Burberry in this regard are trust issues during reorganisation, incomplete data sets, inconsistent access, budgetary considerations and regulatory matters.

4.2 Recommendations

1. **Measure outcomes before adding tools.** Monitor the engagement score through response rate, attrition, and internal mobility and test if these practices complement each other rather than simply making an assumption. Publish numbers where possible to ensure that the people pillar is measured based on performance rather than just words. The current evidence is based on self-reporting. Therefore, it is impossible to test engagement.

2. **Write a short digital HR strategy.** Define how each tool functions and how it helps in the fulfilment of the people pillar, and implement HR tools in decision-making strategies only after establishing basic fundamentals. Use pilot tests with simple experiments, which will fit within a cost-controlled business. Begin from learning, surveys, and reporting tools that have already been developed, and set a benchmark for their success.

3. **Build trust into data use.** A simple charter must be published about what HR data is gathered and why, and colleagues should be involved in developing tools and examining automated scheduling in terms of its impact on autonomy. This should take

place prior to extending the analytics, since more restructuring costs are still to come and there are uncertainties with regard to employment.

4. **Strengthen the data foundation.** The purpose of voluntary identification to increase completeness should be explained, and relevant questions asked, not the modelling of small groups. Small and incomplete sets yield poor conclusions; thus, simple and good questions are more advisable than complex models.

5. **Extend access and manager capability.** Assess how the colleagues from the stores and the factory use the Go1 training platform and HR system via Retail Forward programs and provide guidelines for leading during uncertainty on the B: Managers Hub. Since managers implement change, their ability is critical.

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